Narrative

Elements of Narrative: Suspense vs. Surprise and Repetition

Suspense vs. Surprise

It's important to distinguish between suspense, which has been mentioned in the preceding discussions, and surprise. Although they are often confused, suspense and surprise are two fundamentally different elements in the development of many movie plots.

Because there are no repeat surprises, we can be surprised in the same way only once. As a result, a surprise, being taken unawares, can be shocking, and our emotional response to it is generally short-lived. By contrast, suspense is a more drawn-out (and, some would say, more enjoyable) experience, one that we may seek out even when we know what happens in a movie. Suspense is the anxiety brought on by a partial uncertainty: the end is certain, but the means is uncertain. Or, even more interestingly, we may know both the result and the means by which it's brought about, but we still feel suspense: we know what's going to happen, so we feel compelled to warn and protect the characters who don't.

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Suspense Versus Surprise

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We witness a brutal murder committed by what appears to be a woman named Mrs. Bates in Alfred Hitchcock's thriller *Psycho* (1960). So when private detective Milton Arbogast sneaks into Mrs. Bates' house to question someone he thinks is a harmless little old lady, our awareness generates suspense. Every oblivious step he takes as he treads deeper into the creepy house is invested with the tension of the inevitable attack.

***Psycho* (Alfred Hitchcock, 1960)**

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Hitchcock intensifies the suspense by showing us (but not Arbogast) a shot of Mrs. Bates'

bedroom door gliding open. The director saves *Psycho*'s surprise for the end of the movie, when he suddenly reveals shocking new information to the audience and the principal characters: Mrs. Bates is long dead, and her timid son is the actual psychotic killer.

***Psycho* (Alfred Hitchcock, 1960)**

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Repetition

The **repetition**, or number of times, that a story element recurs in a plot is an important aspect of narrative form. If an event occurs once in a plot, we accept it as a functioning part of the narrative's progression. Its appearance more than once, however, suggests a pattern and thus a higher level of importance. Like order and duration, then, repetition serves not only as a means of relaying story information but also as a signal that a particular event has a meaning or significance that should be acknowledged in our interpretation and analysis.

Story events can be repeated in various ways. A character may remember a key event at several times during the movie, indicating the psychological, intellectual, or physical importance of that event.

The **familiar image** is defined by film theorist Stefan Sharff as compositions, graphic elements, sounds, or juxtapositions that a director periodically repeats in a movie (with or without variations) to help inform or stabilize its narrative. By its repetition, the image calls attention to itself as a narrative (as well as visual) element.

The Night of the Hunter (Charles Laughton, 1955)

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Lighting and Familiar Image in *The Night of the Hunter*

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